

Heteronym (linguistics)

A **heteronym** (also known as a **heterophone**) is a word that has a different pronunciation and meaning from another word but the same spelling. These are homographs that are not homophones. Thus, *lead* (a metal element) and *lead* (a leash or halter to direct an animal) are heteronyms, but *mean* (intend) and *mean* (average) are not (since they are pronounced the same). Heteronym pronunciation may vary in vowel realisation, in stress pattern (see also Initial-stress-derived noun), or in other ways.

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Description

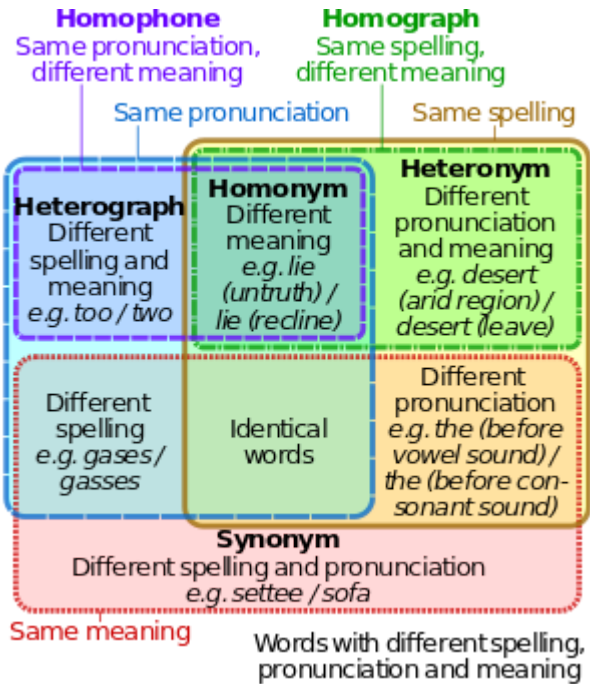
A heteronym is a homograph that is not a homophone, a word that has a different pronunciation and meaning from another word with the same spelling. Heteronym pronunciation may vary in vowel realisation, in stress pattern, or in other ways.

"Heterophone" literally just means "different sound", and this term is sometimes applied to words that are just pronounced differently, irrespective of their spelling. Such a definition would include virtually every pair of words in the language, so "heterophone" in this sense is normally restricted to instances where there is some particular reason to highlight the different sound. For example, puns normally involve homophones, but in the case of heterophonic (or imperfect) puns, the two words sound different, and yet similar enough for one to suggest the other (for example, *mouth* and *mouse*).

Types

Most heteronyms are doubles. Triple heteronyms are extremely rare; two examples, *sin* and *mobile*, are listed below.

Proper nouns can sometimes be heteronyms. For example, the final syllable of Oregon is pronounced like the word *in* by residents of that state in the United States, while in the name of the village of Oregon in Wisconsin, the final syllable is pronounced like the word *on*. Other examples include local pronunciations of Cairo, Georgia; Versailles, Kentucky; and



Euler diagram showing the relationships between heteronyms and related linguistic concepts.